

- 6.c) Discuss Geertz's notion of "thick description" in ethnographic research. How does this concept contribute to understanding cultural meanings and symbols? (15 marks)

Clifford Geertz of Interpretive Schools proposes the idea of Thick description as a way of writing ethnography.

Borrowed from Charles Ryle,

thick description calls for conveying deeper underlying meanings of cultural phenomenon. It calls for presenting the hidden implicit meaning known to the natives as against surface thin description.

→ Blink vs Wink: Blink is a body muscular movement is a thin description, but wink which may convey some hidden meaning, emotion, or signal.

to a friend is a thick description.

Concept Contributing to to understanding cultural meanings and symbols :

→ for Geertz, an ethnographer should act like a hermeneutic, i.e. an interpreter who should get into the shoes of the natives and present a thick description.

⇒ Thick description helps in understanding the native's point of view & how they perceive the world.

⇒ Ex: Geertz presented a thick description of Balinese cock fight.

He suggested it was

not just a game but carried
deeper meanings.

→ It represented social hierarchies,
resolved conflicts and acted as a
mark of status and reputation.

This way Geertz idea of thick
description improves our cultural
understanding of meaning.